Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2022)

I. Global Governance

The International Federation of Pickleball (IFP) serves as the World Governing Body for the sport, while USA Pickleball (USAPA) governs the sport within the United States [cite: 2]. Both organizations are responsible for formulating and interpreting rules to preserve the traditional nature and character of the sport [cite: 2]. The first official rulebook was published by USA Pickleball in March 1984, and the IFP version was adapted from it to facilitate international growth [cite: 3].

II. Equipment & Court Standards

Court dimensions remain standardized at 20 feet by 44 feet for all forms of play [cite: 2]. The net height is set at 36 inches at the sidelines and 34 inches at the center [cite: 2]. The 2022 guidelines emphasize that equipment used in sanctioned tournaments must meet specific rigid and non-compressible material standards to ensure fair play [cite: 2]. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) remains a critical 7-foot area on both sides of the net where volleying is strictly prohibited [cite: 2].

III. Service and The "Drop Serve"

Traditional Volley Serve

The server must use an underhand stroke with the paddle contacting the ball below the waist [cite: 2]. The arm must move in an upward arc at the time of impact, and the highest point of the paddle head must be below the wrist [cite: 2].

The Provisional Drop Serve

The 2022 rules continue to recognize the 'drop serve' as an alternative method [cite: 2]. In this version, the server releases the ball from any height and allows it to bounce before hitting it [cite: 2]. When using the drop serve, the restrictions regarding the upward arc and paddle head position do not apply, provided the ball is hit after a natural bounce [cite: 2].

IV. Gameplay Mechanics

The Two-Bounce Rule requires that the ball bounce once on the receiver's side and once on the server's side before any volleys can occur [cite: 2]. The Non-Volley Zone rules are strictly enforced; it is a fault if a player's momentum causes them to touch the NVZ or its

lines immediately after a volley [cite: 2]. This momentum rule applies even if the ball is declared dead before the player touches the zone [cite: 2].

V. Scoring and Faults

Scoring Fundamentals:
* Points can only be scored by the serving team [cite: 2].
* In doubles, the score is called as three numbers (Server Score, Receiver Score, Server Number) [cite: 2].
* In singles, the score is called as two numbers (Server Score, Receiver Score) [cite: 2].

Common Faults:
* Hitting the ball out of bounds or into the net [cite: 2].
* Stepping into the NVZ while volleying or during the follow-through momentum [cite: 2].
* Serving into the wrong court or failing to clear the NVZ line on the serve [cite: 2].